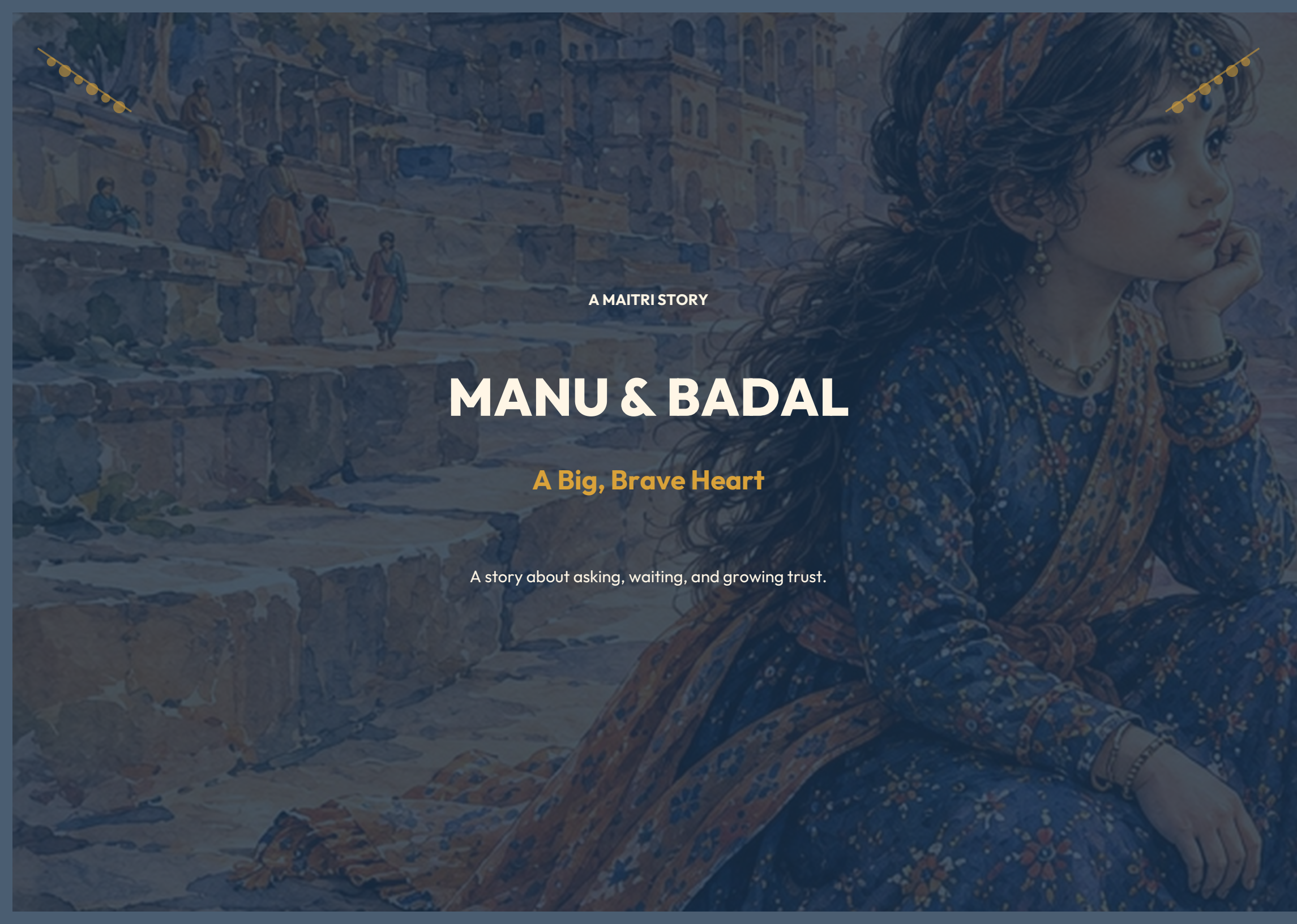


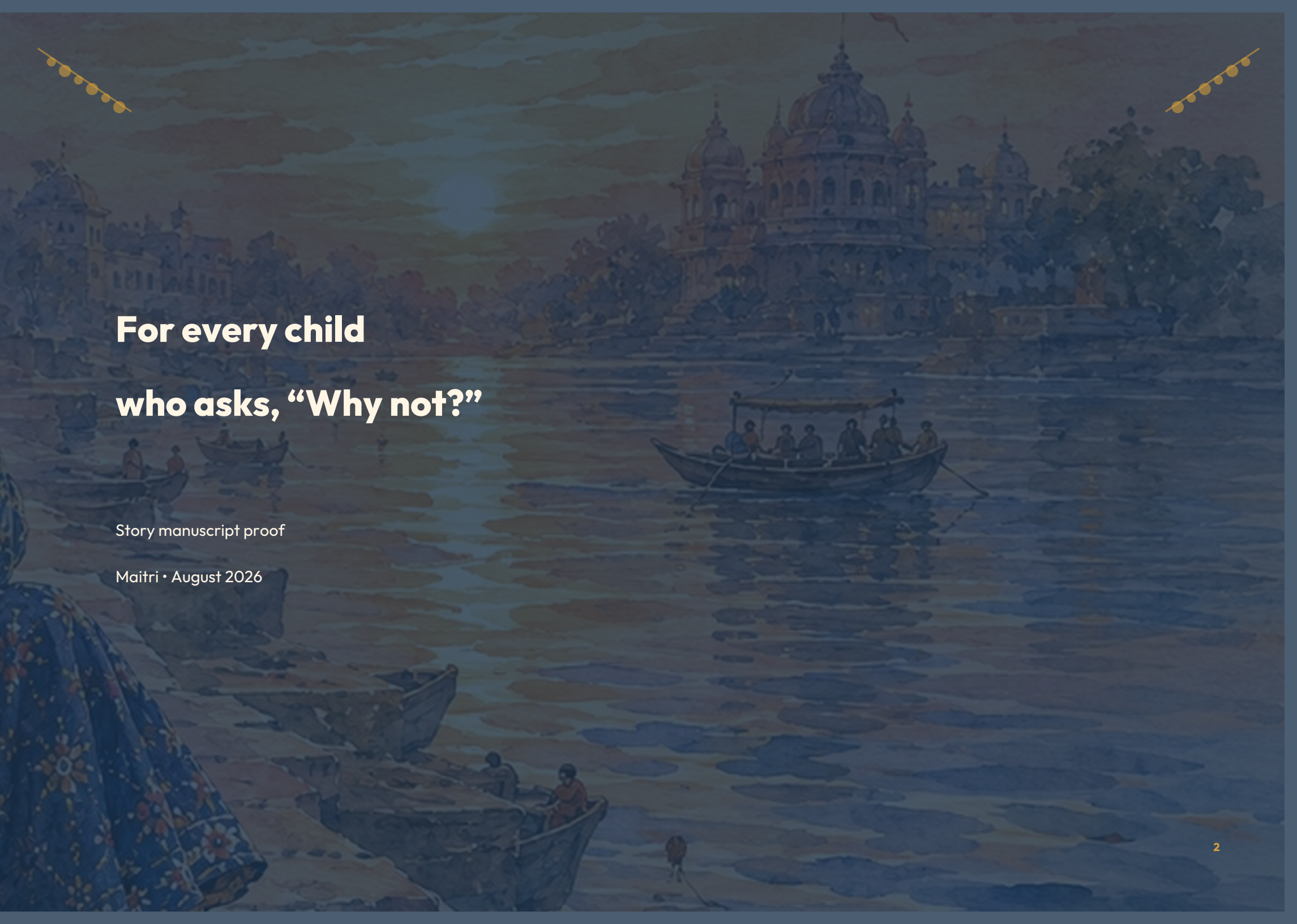


A MAITRI STORY

MANU & BADAL

A Big, Brave Heart

A story about asking, waiting, and growing trust.

The background is a stylized illustration of a river scene. In the foreground, a large boat with a canopy is filled with people. Several smaller boats are also on the water. In the background, a large, ornate building with multiple domes and arches sits on a hill. The sky is filled with soft, colorful clouds. The overall color palette is muted, with a lot of blues, greys, and soft pinks. In the top corners, there are decorative elements resembling strings of lights or garlands.

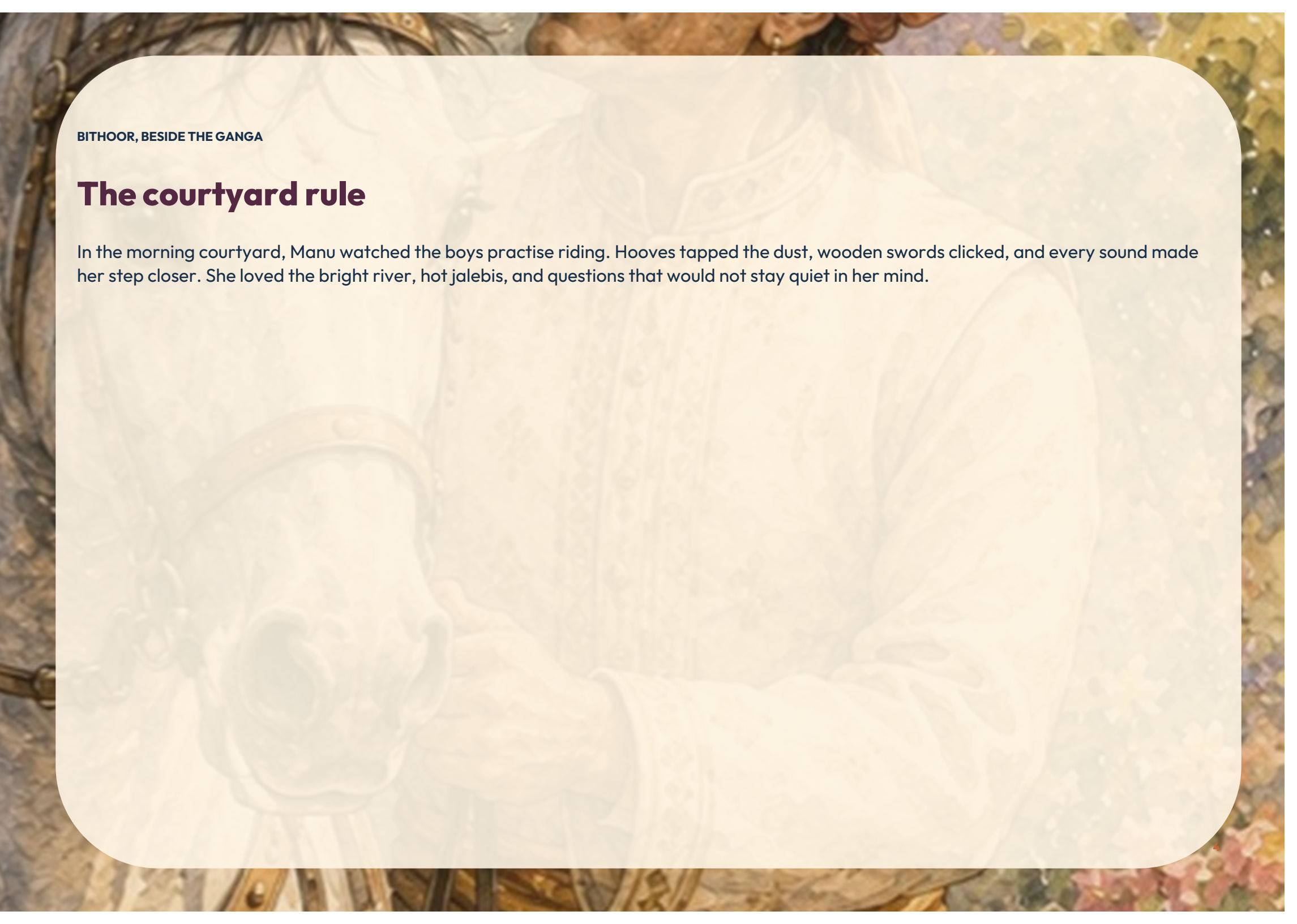
For every child who asks, “Why not?”

Story manuscript proof

Maitri • August 2026



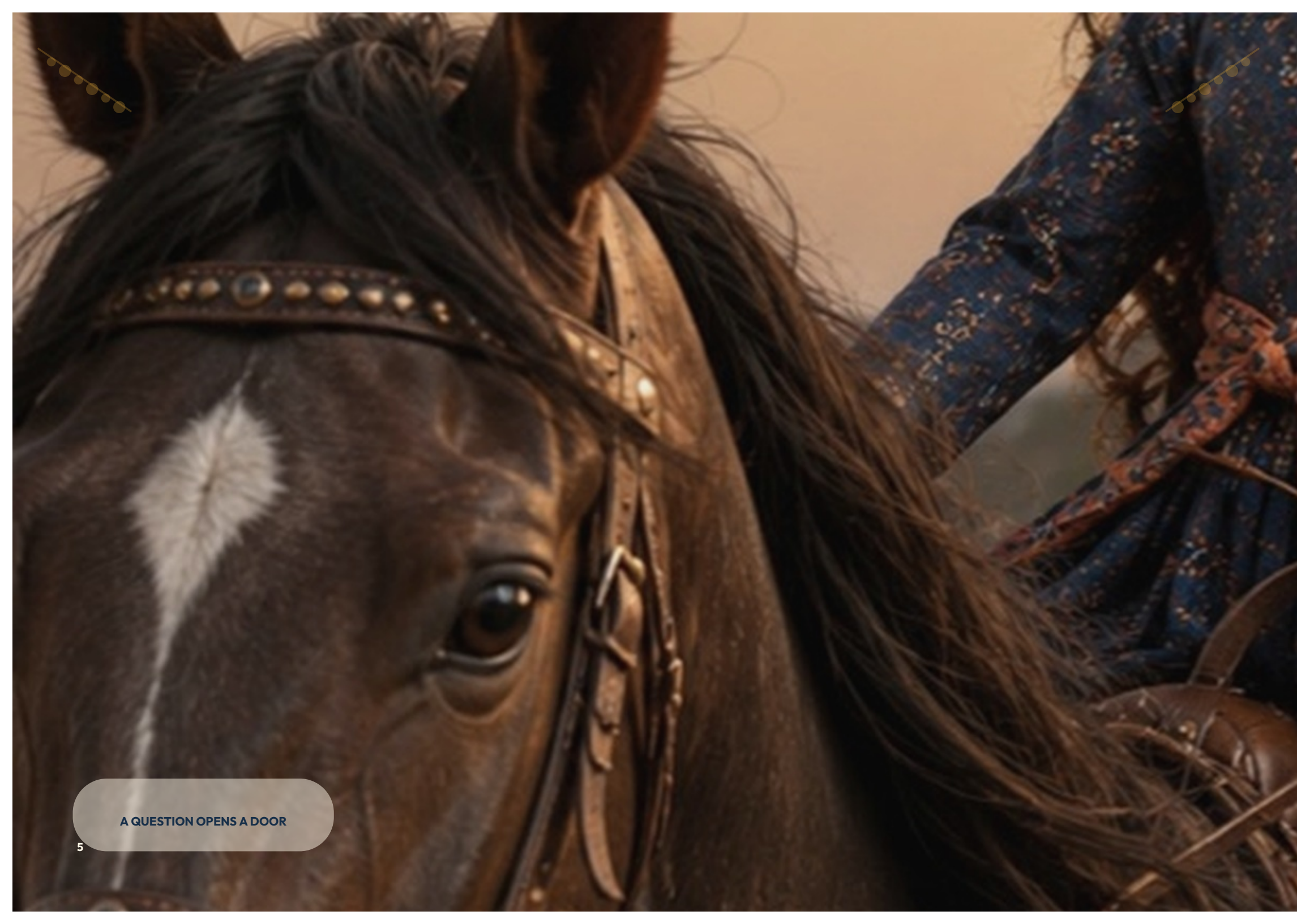
BITHOOR, BESIDE THE GANGA



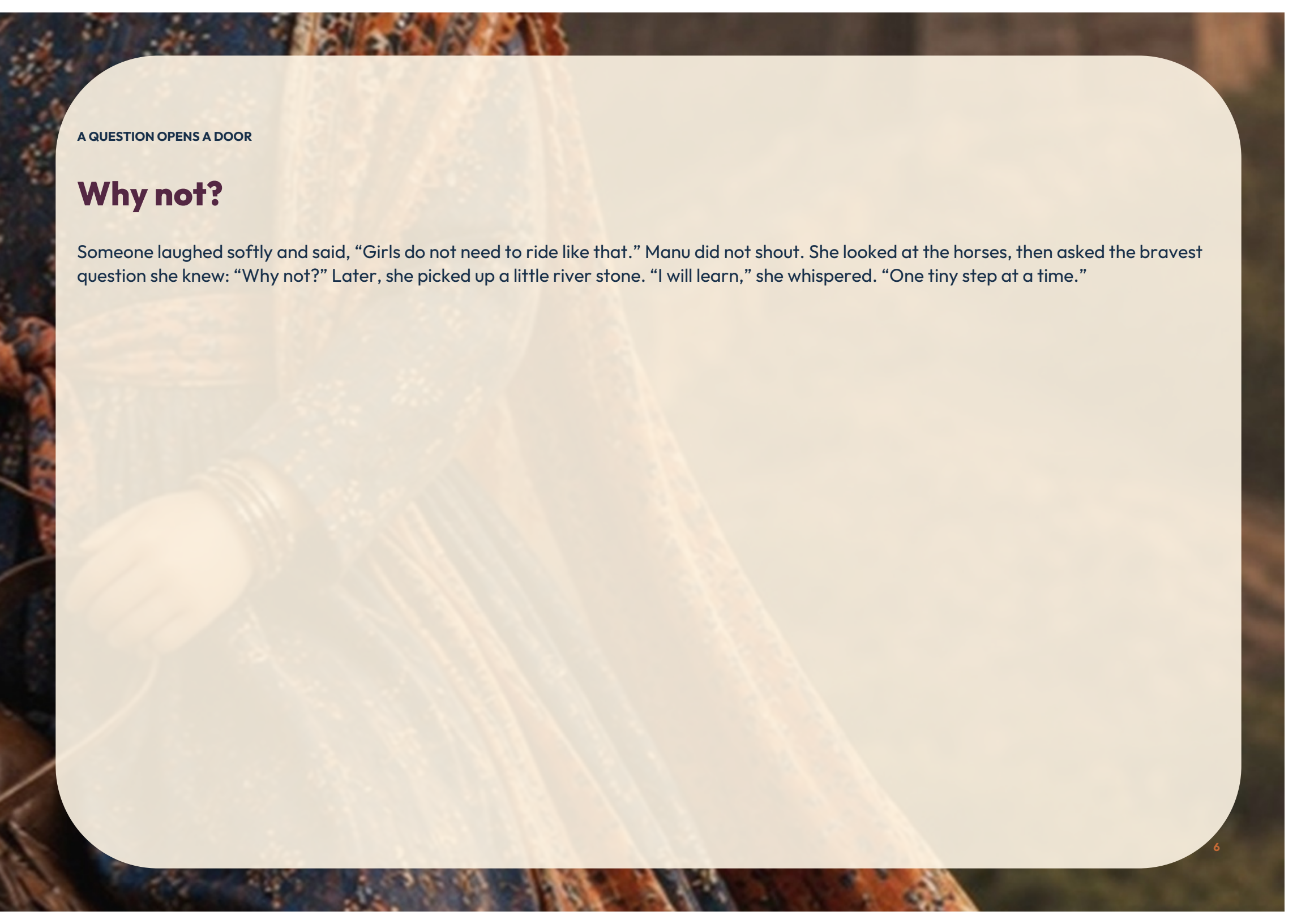
BITHOOR, BESIDE THE GANGA

The courtyard rule

In the morning courtyard, Manu watched the boys practise riding. Hooves tapped the dust, wooden swords clicked, and every sound made her step closer. She loved the bright river, hot jalebis, and questions that would not stay quiet in her mind.



A QUESTION OPENS A DOOR



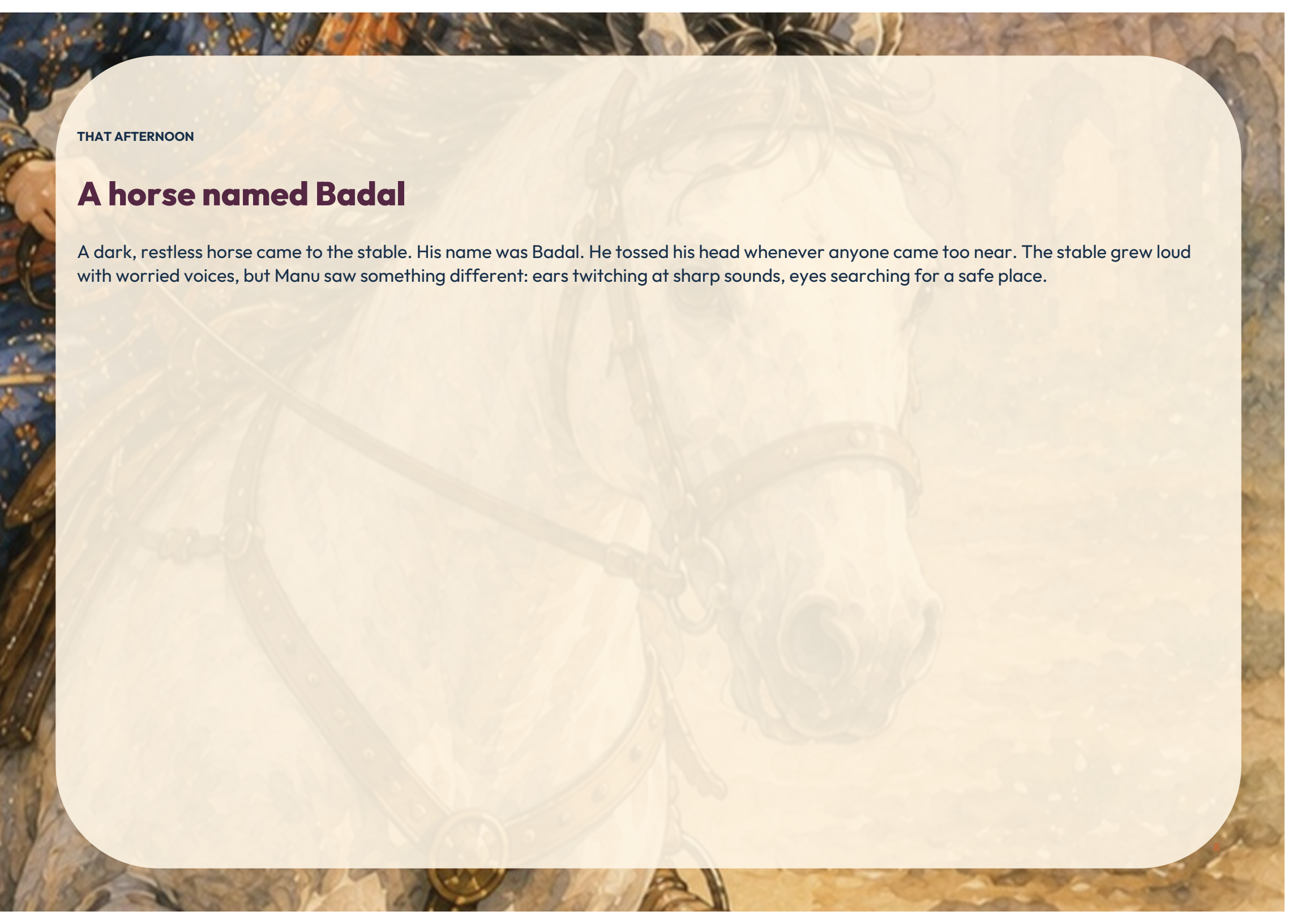
A QUESTION OPENS A DOOR

Why not?

Someone laughed softly and said, “Girls do not need to ride like that.” Manu did not shout. She looked at the horses, then asked the bravest question she knew: “Why not?” Later, she picked up a little river stone. “I will learn,” she whispered. “One tiny step at a time.”



THAT AFTERNOON



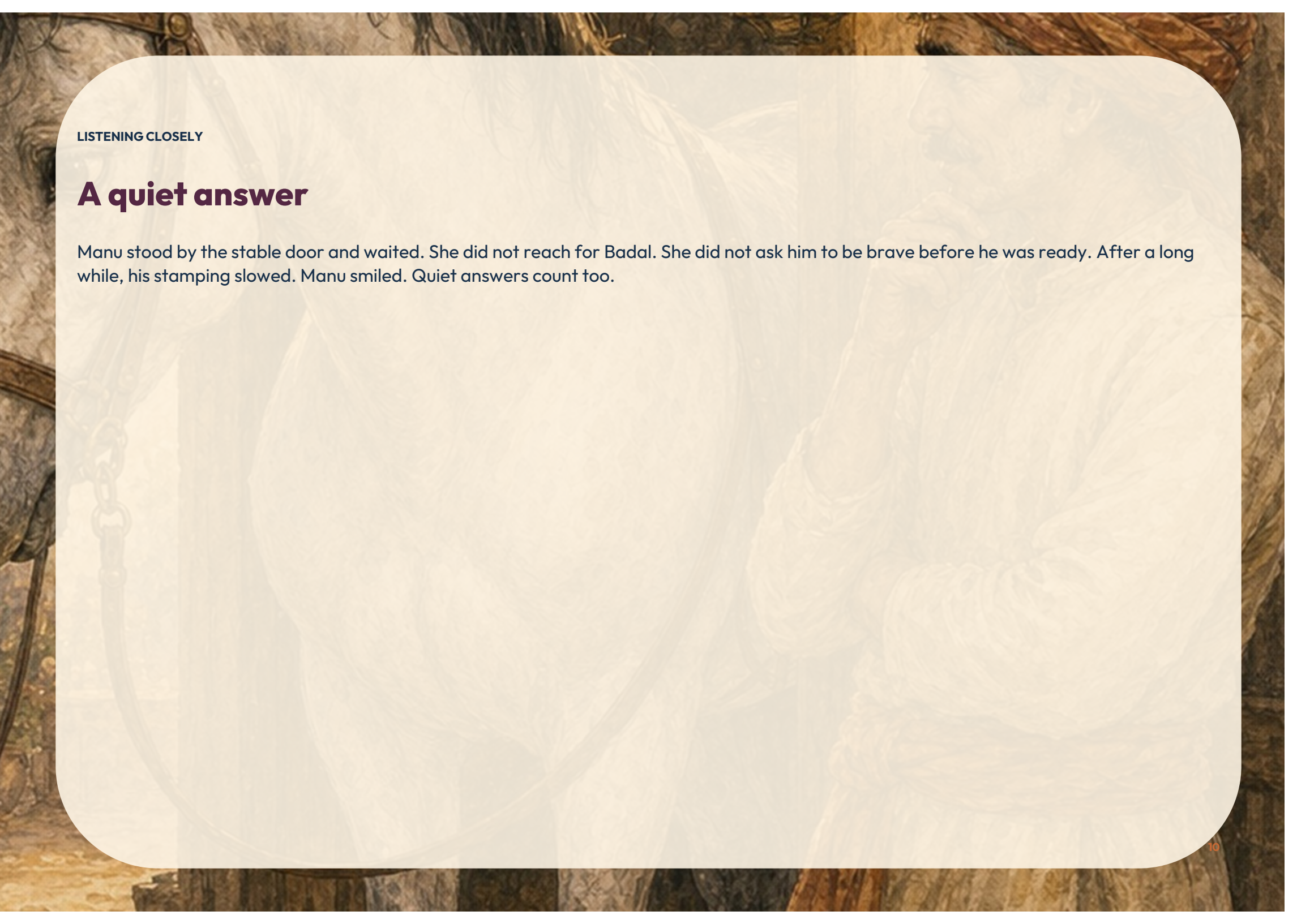
THAT AFTERNOON

A horse named Badal

A dark, restless horse came to the stable. His name was Badal. He tossed his head whenever anyone came too near. The stable grew loud with worried voices, but Manu saw something different: ears twitching at sharp sounds, eyes searching for a safe place.



LISTENING CLOSELY

The background of the slide is a faded, artistic image of a person, possibly a religious figure, wearing a long white robe. The person is shown from the waist up, with their head slightly bowed and hands clasped in front of them. The image has a soft, painterly quality with visible brushstrokes.

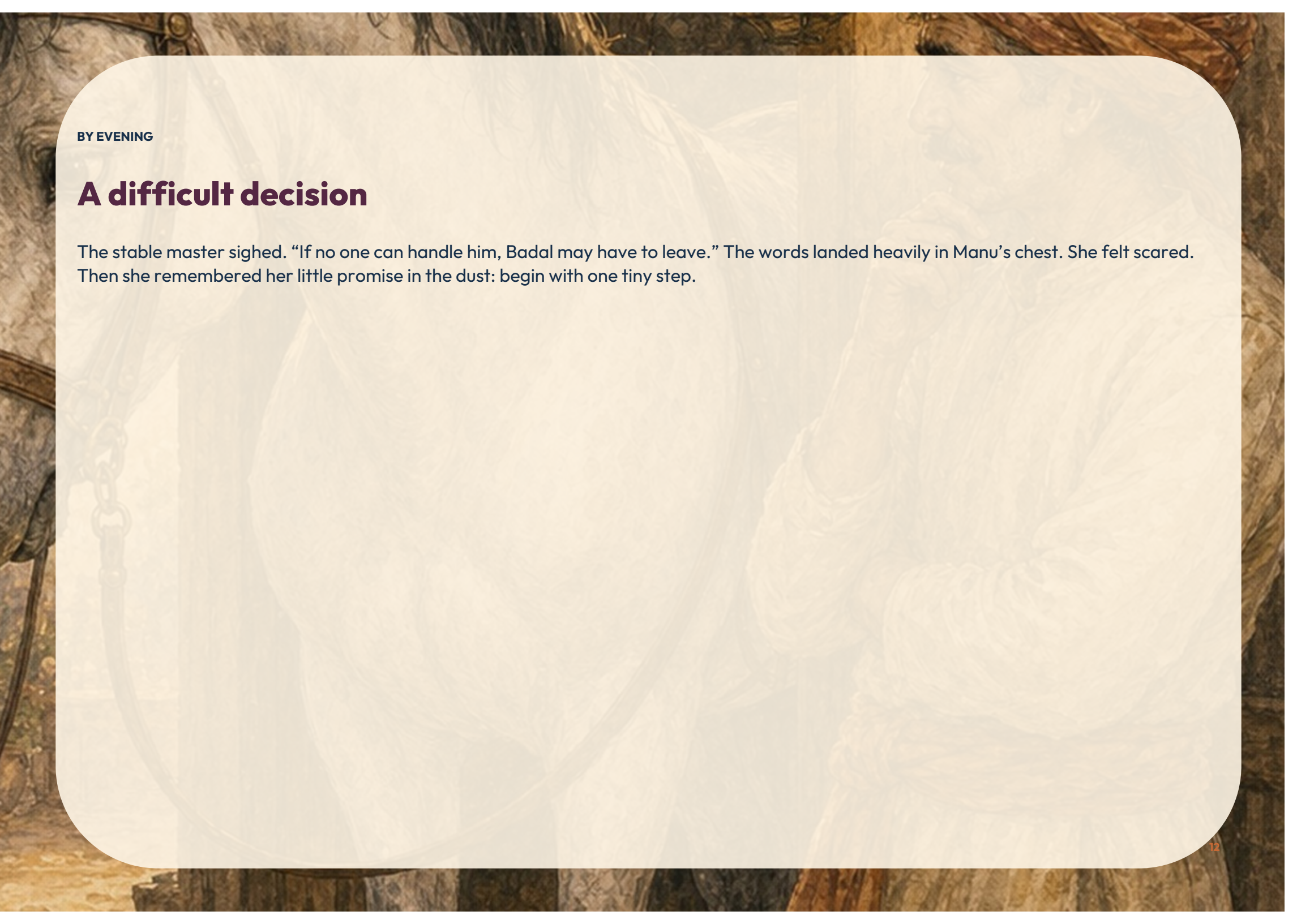
LISTENING CLOSELY

A quiet answer

Manu stood by the stable door and waited. She did not reach for Badal. She did not ask him to be brave before he was ready. After a long while, his stamping slowed. Manu smiled. Quiet answers count too.



BY EVENING



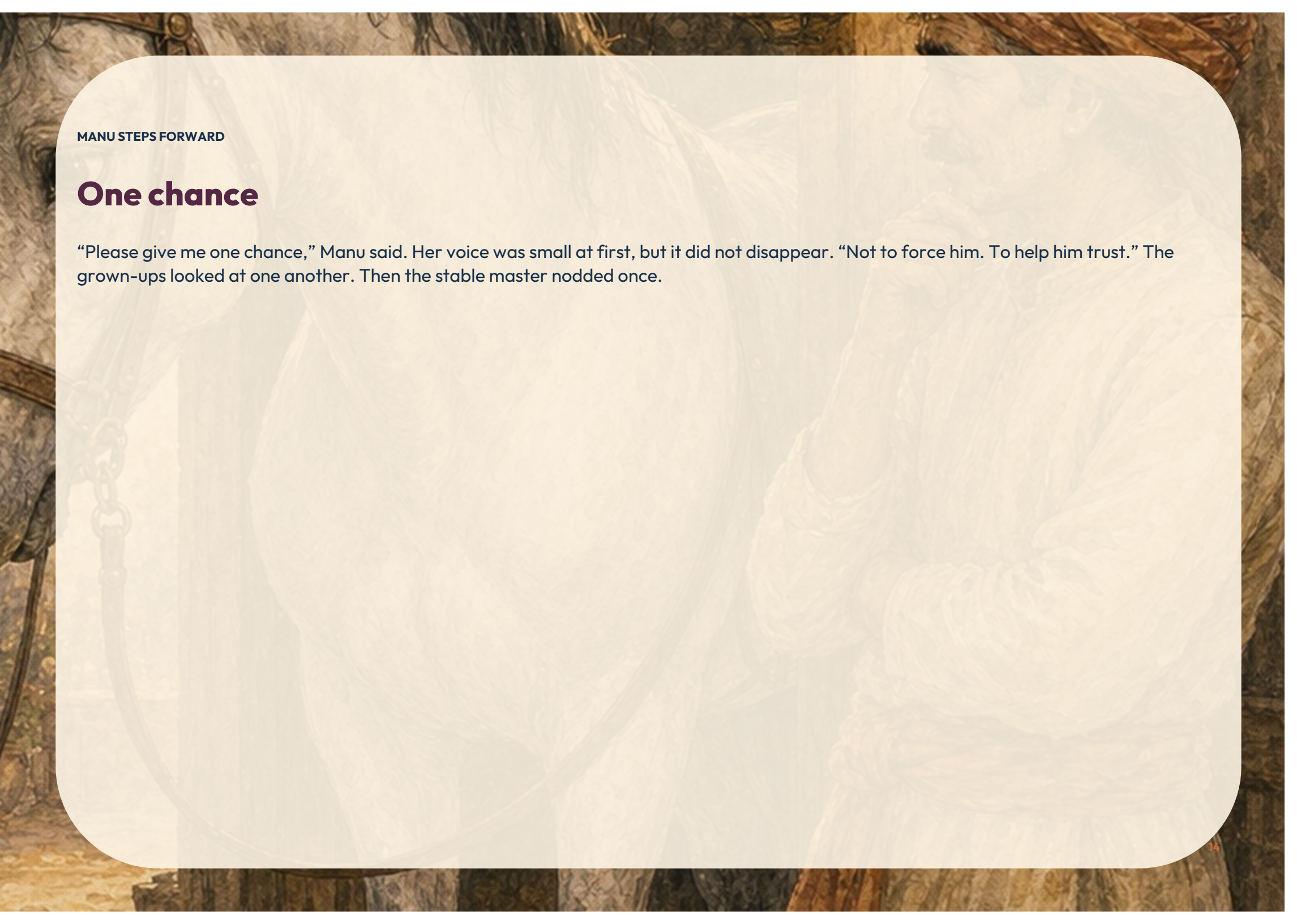
BY EVENING

A difficult decision

The stable master sighed. “If no one can handle him, Badal may have to leave.” The words landed heavily in Manu’s chest. She felt scared. Then she remembered her little promise in the dust: begin with one tiny step.



MANU STEPS FORWARD



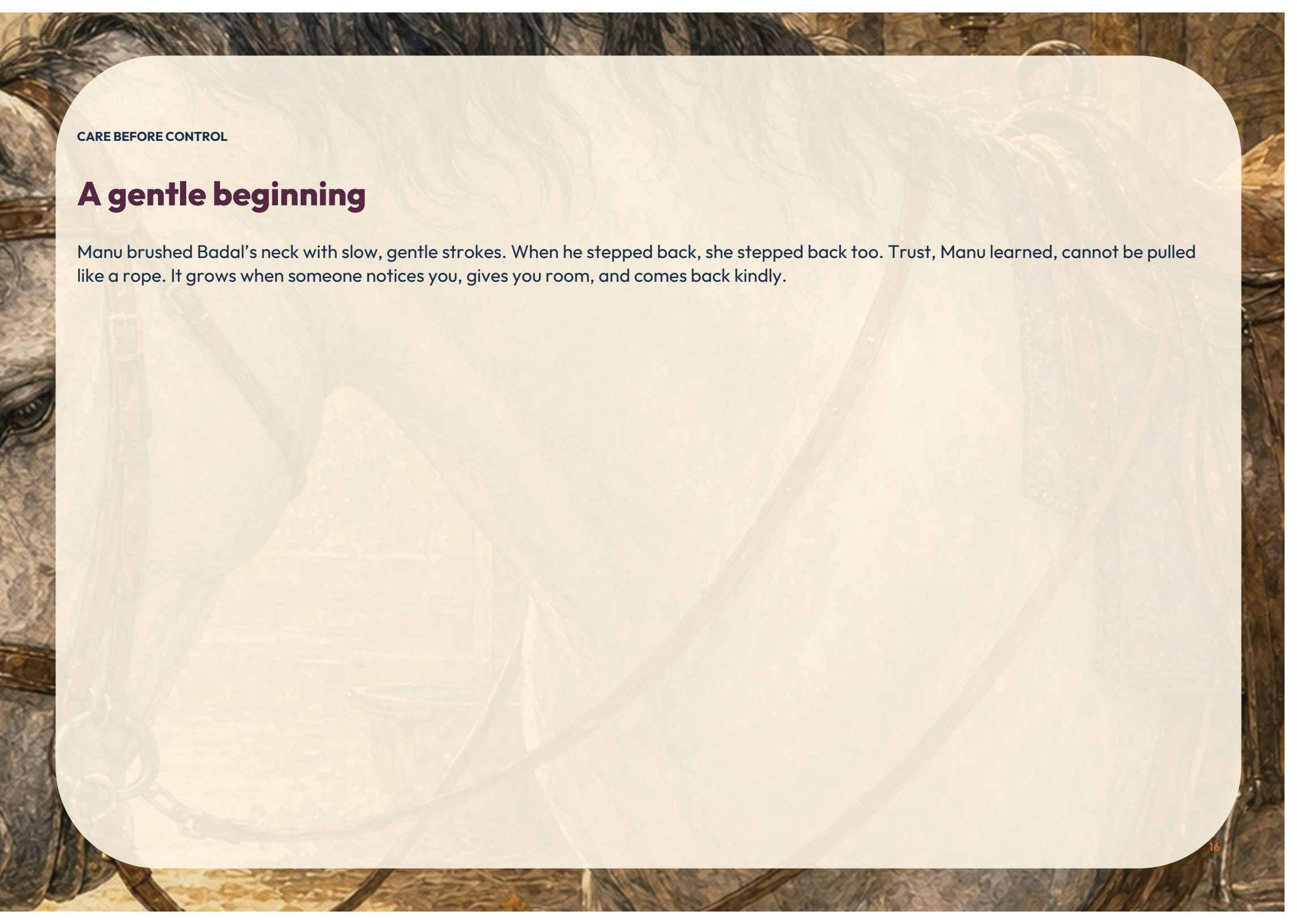
MANU STEPS FORWARD

One chance

“Please give me one chance,” Manu said. Her voice was small at first, but it did not disappear. “Not to force him. To help him trust.” The grown-ups looked at one another. Then the stable master nodded once.



CARE BEFORE CONTROL



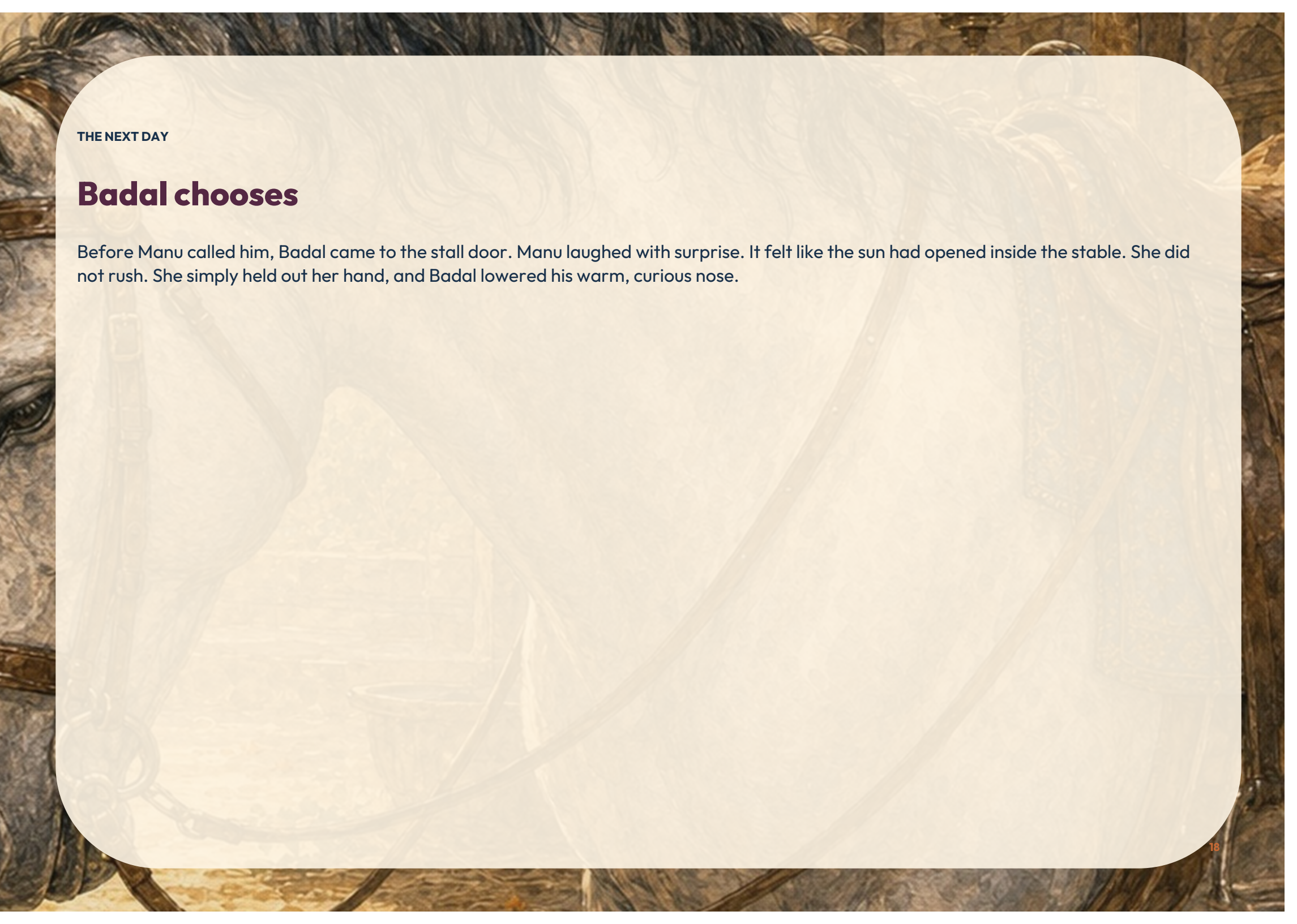
CARE BEFORE CONTROL

A gentle beginning

Manu brushed Badal's neck with slow, gentle strokes. When he stepped back, she stepped back too. Trust, Manu learned, cannot be pulled like a rope. It grows when someone notices you, gives you room, and comes back kindly.



THE NEXT DAY



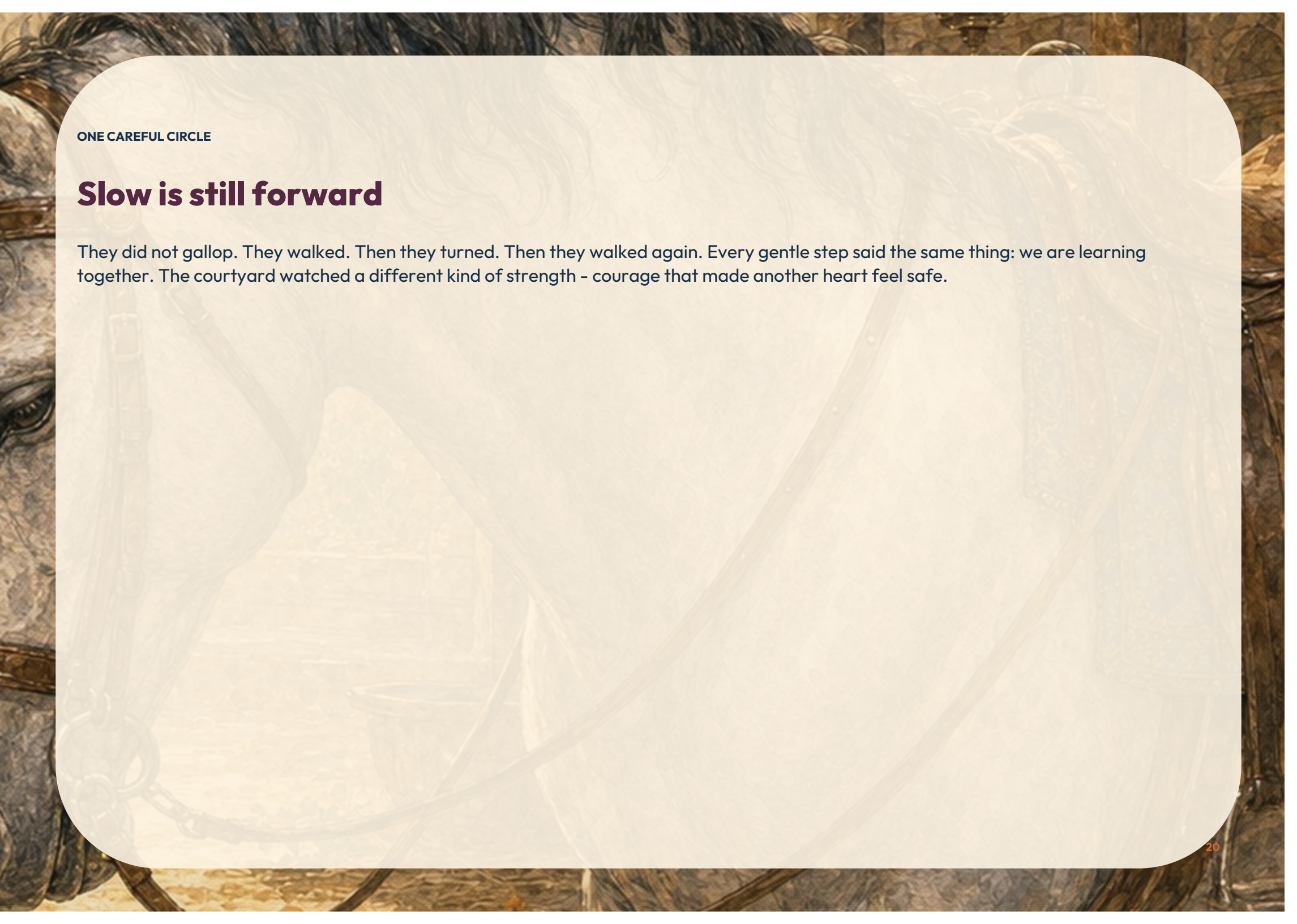
THE NEXT DAY

Badal chooses

Before Manu called him, Badal came to the stall door. Manu laughed with surprise. It felt like the sun had opened inside the stable. She did not rush. She simply held out her hand, and Badal lowered his warm, curious nose.



ONE CAREFUL CIRCLE



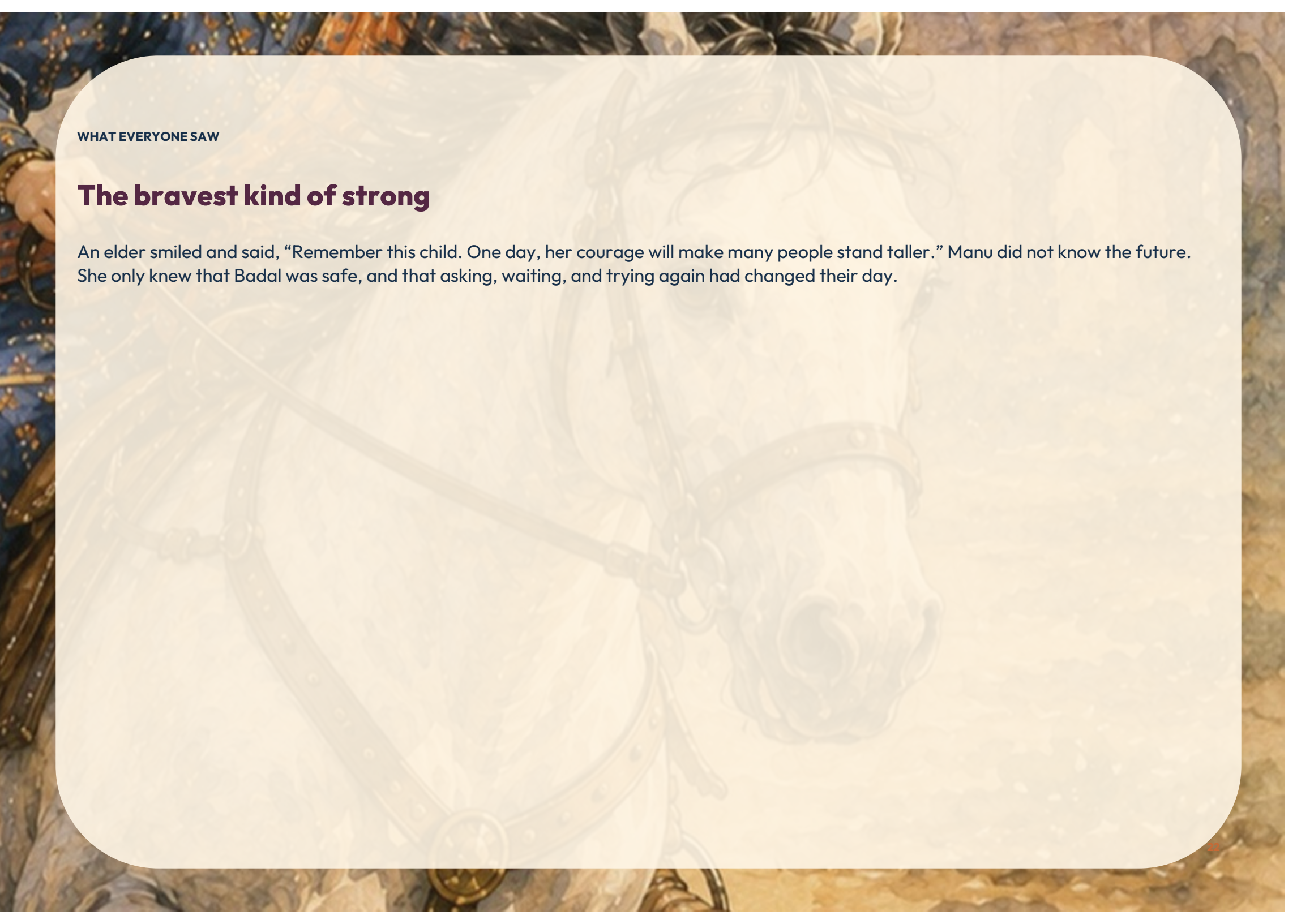
ONE CAREFUL CIRCLE

Slow is still forward

They did not gallop. They walked. Then they turned. Then they walked again. Every gentle step said the same thing: we are learning together. The courtyard watched a different kind of strength - courage that made another heart feel safe.



WHAT EVERYONE SAW



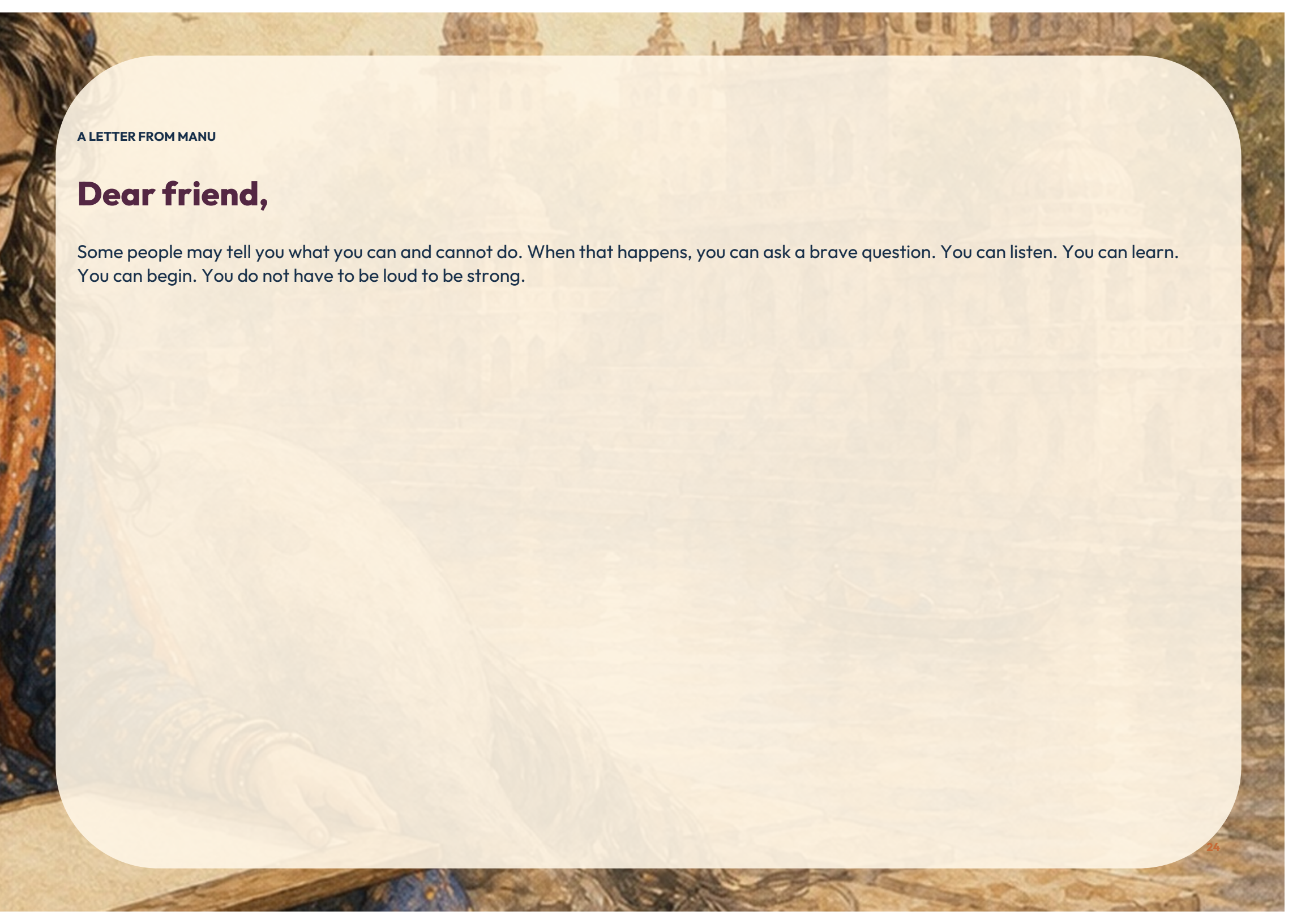
WHAT EVERYONE SAW

The bravest kind of strong

An elder smiled and said, “Remember this child. One day, her courage will make many people stand taller.” Manu did not know the future. She only knew that Badal was safe, and that asking, waiting, and trying again had changed their day.



A LETTER FROM MANU



A LETTER FROM MANU

Dear friend,

Some people may tell you what you can and cannot do. When that happens, you can ask a brave question. You can listen. You can learn. You can begin. You do not have to be loud to be strong.



KEEP THIS CLOSE



KEEP THIS CLOSE

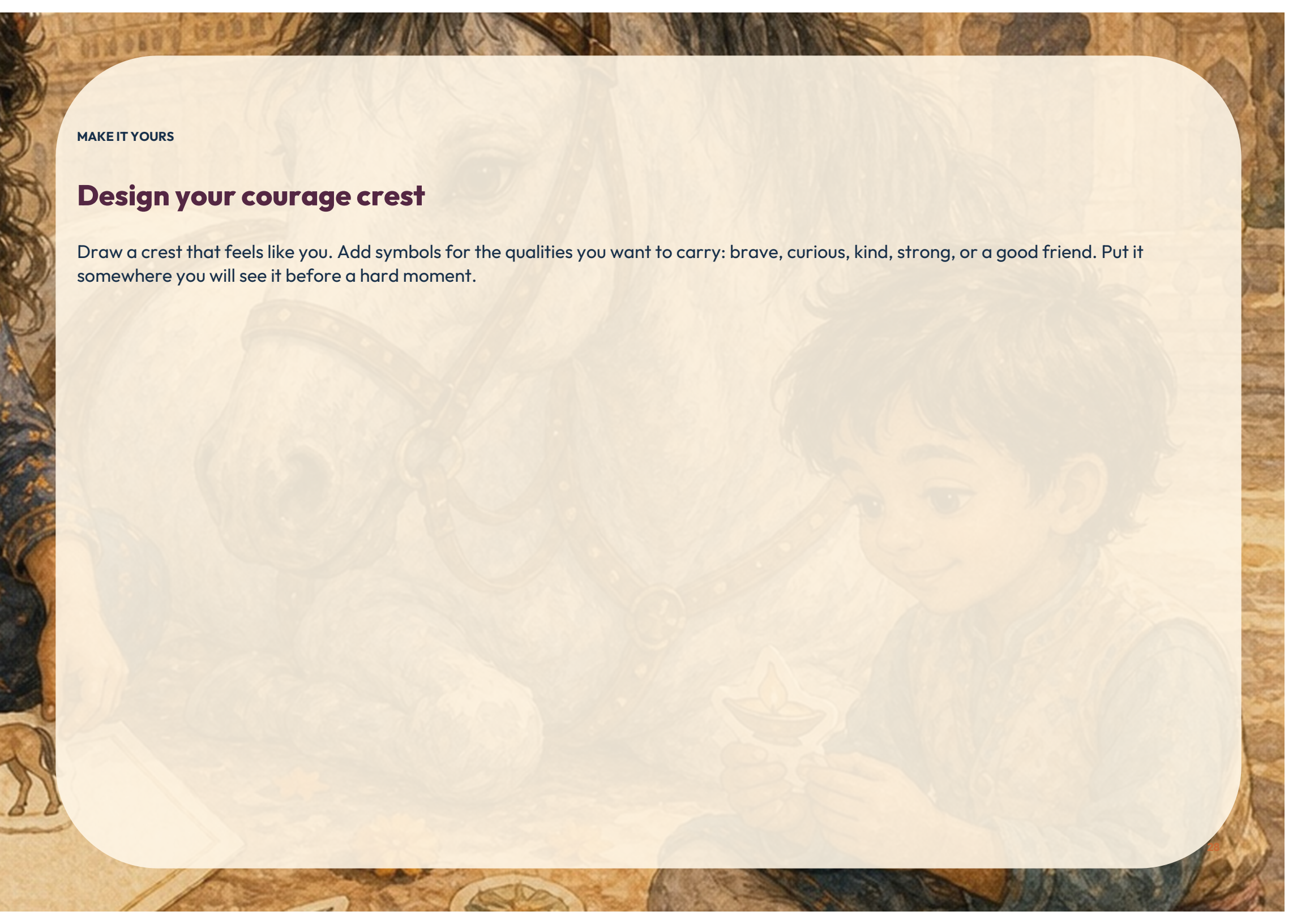
One kind step

I was scared too. Courage was not a loud roar for me. It was one small step toward Badal, then another. When you feel scared, take one kind step. That is enough for today. I will be cheering for you.

With friendship,
Manu



MAKE IT YOURS

The background of the page is a soft, faded illustration of a young boy with dark, curly hair, wearing a patterned vest over a blue shirt. He is holding a small, lit oil lamp. Next to him is the head of a white horse with a brown halter. The scene is set against a stone wall. The entire illustration is overlaid with a semi-transparent white rounded rectangle that contains the text.

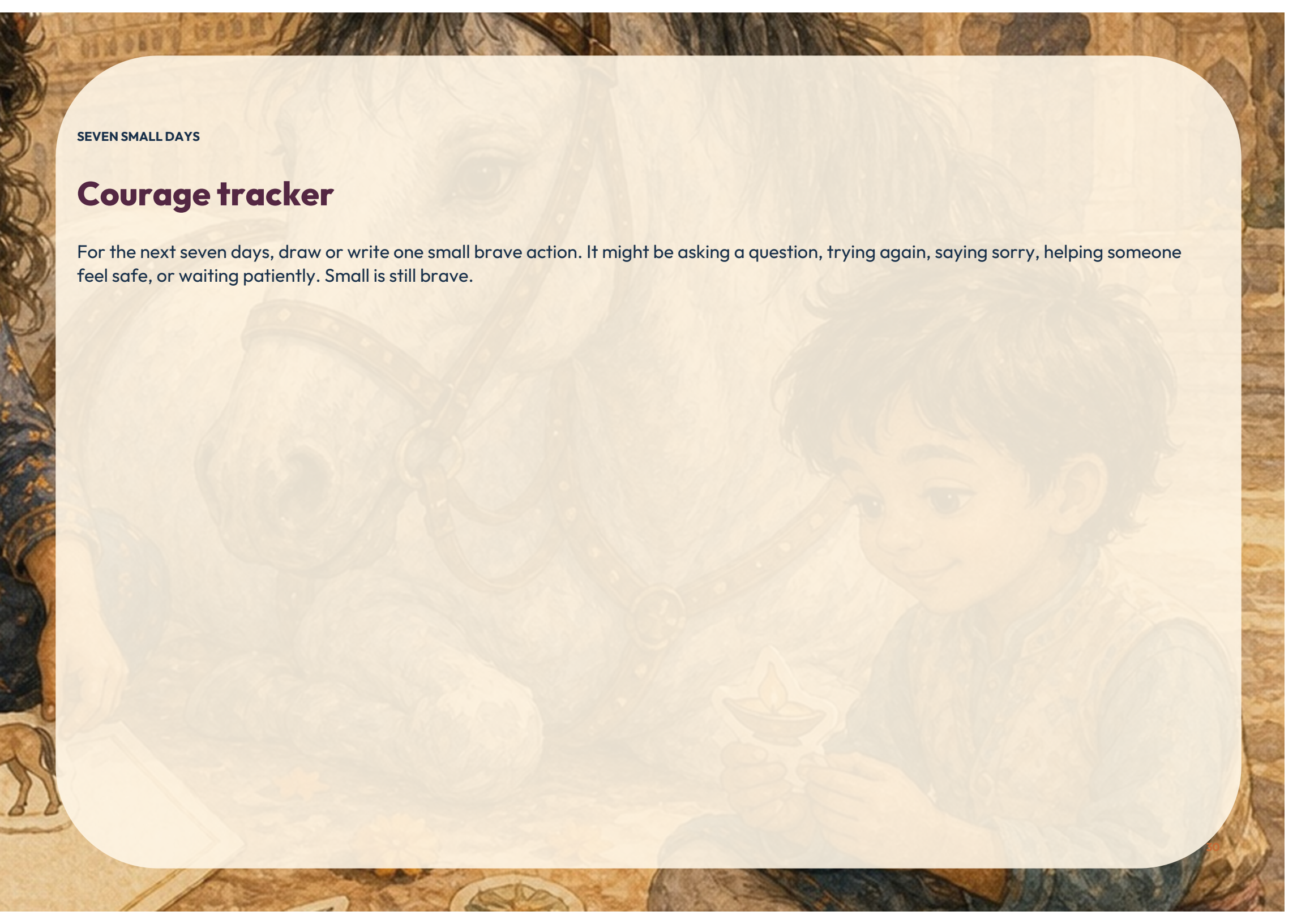
MAKE IT YOURS

Design your courage crest

Draw a crest that feels like you. Add symbols for the qualities you want to carry: brave, curious, kind, strong, or a good friend. Put it somewhere you will see it before a hard moment.



SEVEN SMALL DAYS

The background of the page is a soft, faded illustration. It depicts a young boy with dark, curly hair, wearing a patterned vest over a light blue shirt. He is kneeling and holding a small, lit oil lamp in his hands, looking down at it with a gentle smile. To his left is the head of a white horse with a dark mane, wearing a bridle. The scene is set against a backdrop of stone walls and a wooden floor.

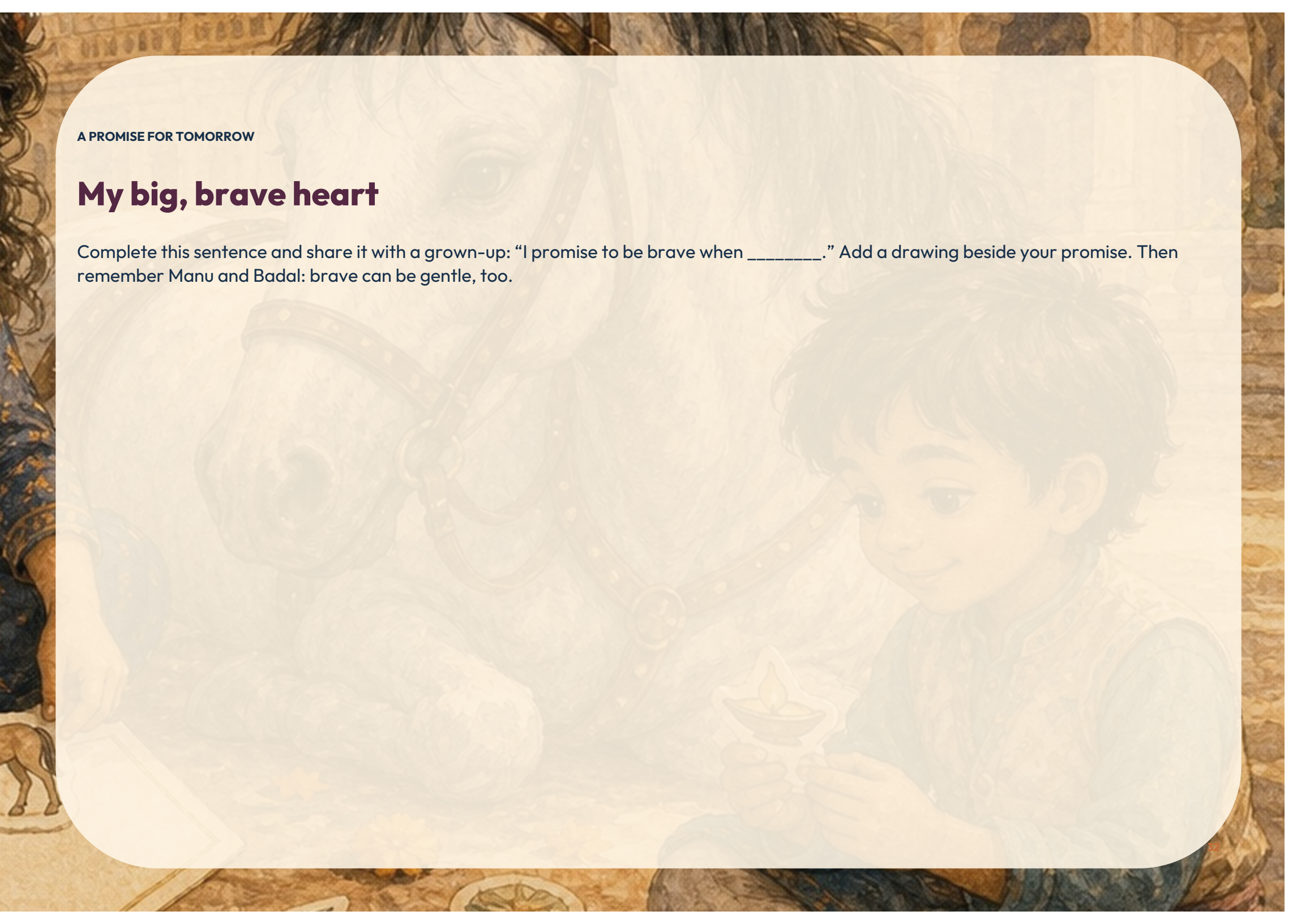
SEVEN SMALL DAYS

Courage tracker

For the next seven days, draw or write one small brave action. It might be asking a question, trying again, saying sorry, helping someone feel safe, or waiting patiently. Small is still brave.



A PROMISE FOR TOMORROW

The background of the page is a soft, faded illustration. It depicts a young boy with dark, curly hair, wearing a patterned vest over a light blue shirt. He is holding a small, lit oil lamp in his hands, looking down at it with a gentle smile. To his left is the head of a white horse, also looking down. The scene is set against a backdrop of a stone wall and some foliage on the left side.

A PROMISE FOR TOMORROW

My big, brave heart

Complete this sentence and share it with a grown-up: “I promise to be brave when _____. ” Add a drawing beside your promise. Then remember Manu and Badal: brave can be gentle, too.